

THE BOLD STORY OF

VAARA

CONSULTING



Nordic Case Challenge

Week of dangerously good impact!

MEET THE TEAM



Julia Zelek

aka the middle child
[LinkedIn](#)



Valeriia Oliukova

aka the guide
[LinkedIn](#)



Veronika Sulak

aka the viking
[LinkedIn](#)



Jonathan Bradshaw

aka the looseur



Ann-Thaïs Dutfield

aka the french bulldog
[LinkedIn](#)

13TH OF MARCH

Four LAB students boarded a flight to Reykjavík, not for a trip, but for a moment.

At Reykjavik University, the Nordic Case Challenge threw us straight into the chaos: high pressure, real stakes, and a live case for Alvotech. Deadlines were tight, expectations even tighter and we were the only all-female team in the room.

Sleep was optional. Stress guaranteed, but we build our confidence in the real time.

Between all day brainstorming, outfit changes before presentations, and “wait, this might actually win” moments, we weren’t just solving a case, we were proving something. To the judges, to the room, and to ourselves.

And when it all came together?

We didn’t just show up, we showed out.

TOP 3.

but we should start from the beginning...

ICELAND, ARE YOU READY?

DAY 1.
SUNDAY
08. MARCH
2026

From prep mode to Artic ambition

On International Women's Day, our small but determined team was ready to do more than just travel, we were ready to make an entrance. As an all-girls team with our ever-steady coach Jonathan Bradshaw, it felt like the right day to begin.

After countless hours at Espresso House, running on caffeine, case slides, and pure ambition, Vaara Consulting was officially en route. Walking into Helsinki Airport, we shared one mindset: confidence, and readiness to see how far we could go.



Wind, snow and reality check

Touching down at Keflavík International Airport felt like stepping into a completely different world, but this time, it wasn't just about the destination, it was the moment we finally saw each other again, after three long months apart, with Julia arriving from the Czech Republic.

By the time we reached Reykjavík, the weather made sure we felt it: wind, snow, and rain from every direction. The short walk to Hotel Natura turned into a mini survival challenge. Slightly frozen and completely wind-blown (except Jonathan), we dropped our bags and headed straight out again.



Dinner, but make it a challenge

The evening took us to a welcome dinner hosted by Reykjavík University—but this wasn't your typical sit-back-and-relax kind of event. Instead of settling in with our own team, we were immediately mixed into new groups with participants from other universities. No warm-up. No comfort zone.

DAY 2.
MONDAY
09 MARCH
2026

DAY TWO: BACK IN THE GAME

Day 1 had already left us:
slightly frozen & out of our
comfort zone

**And Day 2 wasn't any
different.**

Our morning started with the introduction to our first five-hour case company, Carbfix—an Icelandic company turning CO₂ into stone. We could ask questions directly to the company representatives, learning about the challenges, innovations, and the impact of their work.

Once the briefing was over, we formed our newly assigned teams and got straight to work. Hours flew by as we brainstormed ideas, divided tasks, and learned to communicate with teammates we had only just met. It was hard work, but also a crash course in collaboration, creativity, and strategy under pressure.

By afternoon, we were ready to present. Vaara Consulting took the stage in three different divisions and one of our team members even placed first.

Even after the official work was done, the day didn't slow down. We headed to a casual pizza dinner, but the competitive spirit wasn't finished yet. The team organized a blood-serious darts match, our unofficial "second competition" of the day. Jonathan dominated, claiming almost every medal, but laughter and friendly rivalry made the evening unforgettable.



TUESDAY = FUNDAY

DAY 3.
TUESDAY
09 MARCH
2026

An epic Icelandic adventure

After loading up on a very satisfying hotel breakfast, Tuesday gave us a chance to slow down, sit back, and relax. The organizers had something special planned, a bus tour through some of Iceland's most iconic spots.

First stop: the Geysirs. Where, we also got to see an eruption. Followed by a quick **souvenir stop**, because... priorities and a trip around **Golden Circle**.

Next up: Gullfoss waterfall. Absolutely unreal. The kind of place that doesn't even look natural, more like it was designed for a fantasy movie.

We wrapped up the day in the best possible way – soaking in one of Iceland's famous **Blue Lagoons**. Here, we got to connect with students from other universities, share experiences, and leave with a few new friendships.

Safe to say: this wasn't just a "free day" – it was a core memory.

But... let the pictures speak for themselves



DAY 4
WEDNESDAY
11 MARCH
2026

A PEEK INTO BIOSIMILARS



The 15 hours of willpower

After the presentation and a crucial round of Q&A, teams were guided to their working areas. Engrossed with our task, there we researched and strategized, then researched again. Not just the case required strategy, but our writings on the whiteboard as well. Some walls were transparent!

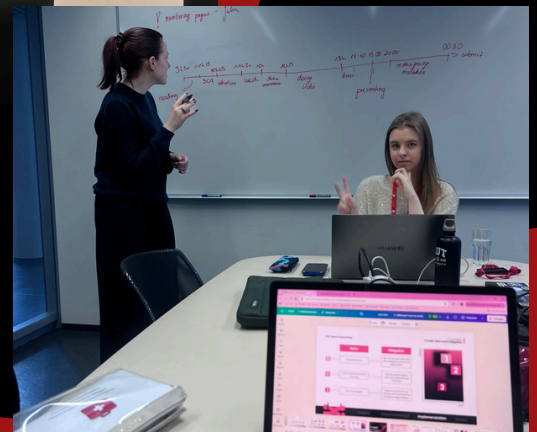
A good lunch at 11:30 gave us renewed energy, and by 14 we were starting on the slides. Veronika addressed insights and analysis, Julia dived into details of our recommendation, Valeriia focused on implementation and risks, and Ann-Thais navigated through the financials.



Ready for fierce brainstorm?

In the morning we arrived at the Reykjavik University campus. Full of enthusiasm and wonder of what the big case is going to be. After a relaxing trip day and good sleep, we were ready to crush it.

At 9 am the case was presented. The client? Alvotech, an Icelandic biopharmaceutical company. Our task? Reduce the environmental footprint, adjusting the supply chain.



The cherry on top

Not long before midnight, we called it a day. Exhausted but lifted by anticipation of tomorrow, we headed to the hotel. As we chatted our way through the quiet street, the sight above made us stop. Aurora spanned over the dark sky.

DAY 5
THURSDAY
12 MARCH
2026

LET'S ROCK!

The day has come...

Brace yourselves

Sleep was elusive. As was breakfast, with all the nerves of what was to come. After the final preparations, and persuading ourselves to eat something, we headed to campus. At 8 am we gathered in the same room as the day before. Of course, for the final rehearsals.

The teams were put in three divisions. There were 10 teams, and we knew – one division will have it hardest. Four teams instead of three competing for the finals. We were one of them.



Guess what...

Can we do it?

The presentations began. As the order unfolded, we soon realized, we were to present the last, what somehow felt both the best and the worst position. Despite that, we rocked the floor. The presentation went smoothly, and we handled every question with confidence.

After the first round we finally relaxed, as the stress gave way to new anticipation, would we make it into the finals? We enjoyed lunch and chatted, awaiting the results.

Soon, the finalists were announced: Jomsborg United, Conscious Consultants, and...

Vaara Consulting.

Ten minutes to prepare. A storm of emotions and determination.

No time to dwell, we still had work to do.

READY?

One more time...

We presented second. The final round went well, even if not quite as flawlessly as the first one, as the fatigue started to make itself known. We stayed confident and professional throughout.



Making history

Some more waiting yet again, and the placements were announced, starting from **third place**. Next thing we knew – we were back to the stage, shaking hands with Alvotech representative and receiving our well-deserved certificates.

After a photoshoot we headed to Natura. Elated, relieved, and exhausted we walked together, reflecting on the events and making new plans.



Up for dinner?

The day was not yet over. Alvotech had invited everyone to their headquarters. Over dinner, we talked about the competition, shared stories, and simply enjoyed the moment. Later, some of us continued into the city with other teams, making most from the final night in Iceland.



Tomorrow, we fly...



DAY 6
FRIDAY
13 MARCH
2026

THE FINAL CHAPTER

To the road again

After just a few hours of sleep, on the cold Icelandic morning we boarded the taxi to Keflavík airport at 5 am. A little overwhelmed by all the past events, but proud of our result, we reflected on the work we did and experience we got, thinking of what we should do next.

We passed the security with ease, with the week's tight schedule, some of us still hadn't picked up any souvenirs! With some time to spare, we scavenged Duty-Free and the airport bookstore for chocolate, magnets and keychains. Then, Julia headed to her flight to Czech, and the rest of us - to Helsinki.



With that, the story of Vaara Consulting in Iceland, with all its challenges and highlights, signed its final chapter.

This was an invaluable experience we will never forget.

The final stretch

But Iceland wasn't quite ready to let us go without one final challenge. The flight was overbooked. By an ironic twist of fate, one of us ended up on the standby list. After several nerve-racking minutes of waiting, as some volunteers arrived, we got the desired seat.

The flight itself was smooth, and we arrived on time, some of us finally catching up on sleep. As we got the baggage, we raced against time and made our train – back to Lahti. After an hour of more fruitful discussions, we arrived at the station.

WE ARE

TRULY

THANKFUL
TO...

We'd like to extend a heartfelt **thank you to everyone** who made Nordic Case Challenge 2026 such a unforgettable experience.

To Jonathan Bradshaw, our coach and double winner – you kept us focused, made us laugh when things got too real, somehow believed in us even in the moments we didn't and let's be real, we wouldn't have made it this far without you.

To Carbfix and Alvotech - thank you for giving us real problems that challenged us, stretched us, and made sure our brains were working overtime. Safe to say... we'll never look at a case the same way again.

To our fellow teams - thank you for the energy, conversations, and the competition that pushes you while still feeling like a shared experience. You made this week what it was.

To Reykjavik University and Ásgeir Jónsson – thank you for hosting a week that somehow balanced pressure and remarkable moments so perfectly. Everything ran smoothly and we felt welcomed from start to finish.

And finally, **to LAB University of Applied Sciences** - thank you for trusting us to represent you. We showed up, we pushed through, and we're coming back with a

TOP 3.

